Coarse-to-Fine Text Generation on a Laptop: A Native MLX Study of Next-Concept Modeling

Jan Music
Independent

Abstract

Next-concept modeling (NCM) writes a sequence the way a painter works: a rough sketch first, then finer and finer detail, with every piece of a level produced at once. We reimplement NCM from its paper and released configurations in MLX, Apple's array framework, and study it on an Apple M5 Pro laptop and single NVIDIA GPUs. On a synthetic 15,360-sentence language, a 5M-parameter NCM model is 4–5× faster than an equal-size word-by-word (autoregressive) model at small batch sizes but less accurate (89.8% vs 98.6% valid sentences). On the paper's Sudoku benchmark our autoregressive baseline reproduces the published autoregressive result (13.8% vs 14.6% of easy boards solved), while our NCM, with conditioning corruption and unique-solution puzzles, solves 96.2% of easy, 76.6% of medium and 31.9% of hard boards when trained on 8M sequences (99.5%, 96.5% and 86.1% reported for the original's 4× larger model trained on 51M), far more than the equal-size autoregressive model. We trace the path step by step: the level schedule, a learned first level, conditioning corruption and its strength, and above all training data. We also report that fp32 matrix products on Apple GPUs run at reduced precision and that computing block-diagonal attention per level speeds training by 1.35×.

Keywords: coarse-to-fine generation, residual vector quantisation, parallel decoding, Apple Silicon, MLX

> **Status.** Working paper, version 0.7. Every number here is copied from a run in the code repository (`runs/`, summarised in `paper/data/results.json`) or quoted from the cited paper and marked as quoted. Experiments still running are marked *in progress* and never estimated. Appendix C lists the changes between versions.

1 Reading guide

This paper has two audiences. **If you are new to language models**, read Section 2 (the idea in plain language) and Section 3 (glossary), then the boxed summary at the start of each later section. **If you build models**, Sections 5–7 give the method with every formula explained, the Apple Silicon implementation and the experiments. Section 8 tells the story of the project run by run: what each experiment (E0, E1, …) asked, what changed and what we learned.

2 The idea in plain language

2.1 How a chat model writes

A chat model such as ChatGPT or Qwen writes one *token* (a word or a piece of a word) at a time. To write the 100th token it runs the whole model once, reads what it has written so far and

picks the next token. A 100-token answer therefore needs 100 full runs of the model, one after the other. On a laptop each run must read every weight of the model from memory, so speed is limited by memory bandwidth, not by how fast the chip can calculate.

2.2 How next-concept modeling writes

NCM (Kumbong et al. 2026) writes differently. It first produces a single, very rough "concept" for the whole text, then refines it in a few rounds. Each round adds roughly twice as much detail, and **every piece of detail in a round is produced at the same time**. Figure 1 shows a real example from this project: a 32-character sentence written in six rounds (levels). After level 0 the rough shape is there ("eue likes one oed egg."); by level 2 the words are settled; later levels only change single letters.

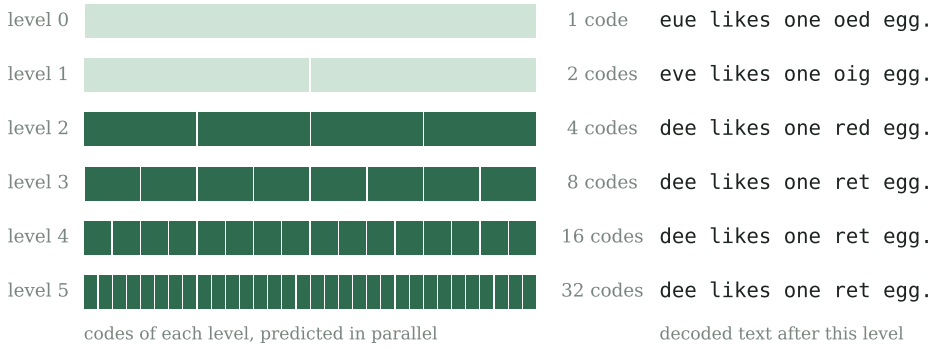


Figure 1: A real generation from experiment E1. Left: the codes of each level; all codes in one row come from one model run. Right: the text obtained by decoding everything up to that level. Six model runs write the sentence; a word-by-word model needs 32. The sample also shows a failure: level 3 turns "red" into "ret", and nothing later repairs it.

The number of rounds is fixed (six here, twelve in the original paper's Sudoku model) and does not grow with the length of the text, so NCM needs far fewer model runs than a word-by-word model. That is where its speed comes from.

2.3 Two parts: a codec and a generator

NCM has two learned parts. An analogy from image files helps.

- The **codec** is like an image format with progressive loading: a JPEG that first shows a blurry picture, then sharpens. It learns to turn a sentence into a stack of codes, from one coarse code to one code per letter, and to turn the codes back into the sentence. It is trained first, on its own, until it rebuilds sentences perfectly.
- The **generator** is the creative part. It learns to *invent* new code stacks one level at a time: level 0, then level 1 given level 0, and so on. The codec then turns the finished stack into text.

2.4 Why it matters, and the catch

Fewer, wider model runs suit a laptop GPU: one run reads the weights once and does a lot of arithmetic with them. The catch is that all codes of a level are chosen at the same moment, so neighbouring pieces cannot see each other's choice. If two pieces of a level disagree, the result can be wrong in a way a word-by-word model would avoid. Much of this paper measures when that matters.

2.5 What we did

We rebuilt NCM from scratch for Apple's MLX framework (Hannun et al. 2023), tested it on a small invented language and on Sudoku puzzles (the original paper's showcase), and compared it with a word-by-word model of the same size and with a large chat model. The speed advantage holds on a laptop. On Sudoku our best model solves 96% of easy boards (the original: 99.5%) and beats a word-by-word model of the same size; Section 8 tells how we got there.

3 Glossary

Table 1: Terms used in this paper.

Term	Meaning
Token	The unit a model reads and writes. Here: one character (TinyWorld) or one Sudoku cell.
Autoregressive (AR) model	A model that writes one token at a time, each conditioned on all previous ones. Chat models are AR models.
Forward pass, NFE	One run of a model on its input. NFE (number of function evaluations) counts forward passes per generated sample.
Parameters	The learned numbers inside a model; "6.4M parameters" means 6.4 million.
Embedding, latent vector	A list of numbers (128–512 here) that represents a token or a position inside the model.
Vector quantisation (VQ)	Replacing a vector by the nearest entry of a fixed list, the *codebook*, so it can be stored as one integer, the *code*.
Codebook, code	The list of allowed vectors at one level (16 or 128 entries here) and the index of one entry.
Level	One round of refinement. Level k has l_k codes; level 0 is the coarsest.
Residual	What is left over: the difference between the true vector and the approximation built so far.
Codec (tokenizer, VQ-VAE)	Stage 1 of NCM: encoder, quantiser and decoder that turn text into codes and back.
Generator	Stage 2 of NCM: the transformer that predicts the codes of each level.
Transformer, attention, mask	The standard neural network for sequences. *Attention* lets each position read information from other positions; a *mask* says which positions may be read.
Teacher forcing	Training on the *true* previous outputs instead of the model's own. Fast, but the model never practises recovering from its own mistakes.
Conditioning corruption	Replacing some true inputs with wrong ones during training so the model learns to cope with its own mistakes.
Cross-entropy (CE), nats	The training loss: how surprised the model is by the right answer, in natural-log units. Lower is better; $\ln 16 \approx 2.77$ nats is a uniform guess among 16 codes.
Perplexity	e^{CE}, the effective number of choices. Code perplexity 1 means a level always uses the same code and carries no information.
Temperature, greedy	Sampling randomness. Temperature 0 (greedy) always takes the most likely choice.
Batch, latency, p50	A batch is several samples generated together; latency is the time for one batch; p50 is the median over repeated runs.
KV cache	A store of past attention values that speeds up AR generation.

Term	Meaning
EMA	Exponential moving average: a running average that slowly forgets old values. Used to update codebooks.
Straight-through estimator	A trick to train through a step that has no gradient (like picking the nearest code) by treating it, for the gradient only, as the identity.
MLX, Metal	Apple's machine-learning array framework, and the GPU interface it runs on.
fp32, bf16	32-bit and 16-bit (bfloat16) floating-point formats.
E0, E1, …	Experiment numbers, in the order the experiments were run (Section 8).

4 Background

Residual vector quantisation. A vector quantiser maps a continuous vector to the nearest of V codebook entries (Oord et al. 2017). Residual quantisation applies several quantisers in sequence, each to what the previous ones left over (Lee et al. 2022; Zeghidour et al. 2021); it underlies modern neural audio codecs.

Next-scale prediction. VAR (Tian et al. 2024) combines residual quantisation with resolution: the first quantiser sees a 1×1 summary of an image, later ones 2×2, 3×3, up to full resolution, and a transformer generates one scale per step. NCM applies the idea to 1-D token sequences (Kumbong et al. 2026).

Diffusion language models refine all positions of a sequence over T denoising steps (Sahoo et al. 2024). Each step processes the full length L; NCM's coarse levels are short, so its total work is closer to one pass over L positions spread across K steps. The NCM paper reports quality at or above strong diffusion language models with 10–31× faster generation on an H100 GPU (Kumbong et al. 2026).

5 Method

> **In short.** The codec learns to describe a sequence with a stack of codes, coarse to fine. The generator learns to predict each level's codes from the levels above it. Generation runs the generator once per level, then decodes.

We follow the NCM design (Kumbong et al. 2026) and its released Sudoku configuration; Table 2 lists where we differ. A running toy example uses a sequence of $L = 8$ tokens, levels $l = (1, 2, 4, 8)$ and vectors of width $C = 2$.

5.1 Codec: from tokens to a stack of codes

Encoder. Each token x_i and its position i are looked up in two tables, added and normalised:

$$z_i = \mathrm{Norm}\left(W_{\mathrm{tok}}[x_i] + W_{\mathrm{pos}}[i] \right), \qquad z \in \mathbb{R}^{L \times C}.$$

Reading it: W_{tok} has one learned row per possible token and W_{pos} one per position; z is the whole sequence as L vectors of C numbers. "Norm" rescales each vector (LayerNorm), or groups of channels across the sequence (GroupNorm, as upstream), without a learned scale, because the quantiser compares squared distances and a learned scale could grow without bound. In the toy example z is an 8×2 table of numbers.

Quantisation, level by level. The quantiser keeps a *residual* r, initially all of z, and for each level $k = 0, \ldots, K-1$ does four things:

$$\underbrace{x_k = D_k\, r_k}_{\text{1. shrink}}, \qquad \underbrace{c_k = \arg\min_j \|x_k - E_k[j]\|^2}_{\text{2. pick nearest codes}},$$

$$\underbrace{q_k = \phi_k\big(U_k\, E_k[c_k]\big)}_{\text{3. expand and refine}}, \qquad \underbrace{r_{k+1} = r_k - \mathrm{sg}(q_k)}_{\text{4. subtract}}.$$

Reading it:

1. **Shrink.** D_k averages the residual down to l_k positions (area pooling). Toy example: for level 1 ($l_1 = 2$), positions 1–4 are averaged into one vector and 5–8 into another.
2. **Pick.** For each of the l_k shrunk vectors, find the nearest of the V codebook entries $E_k[1..V]$; its index is the code. c_k is a list of l_k integers, for example $(5, 12)$.
3. **Expand and refine.** Look the codes back up, stretch them to L positions by linear interpolation (U_k), and apply $\phi_k(h) = (1-\rho)\,h + \rho\,\mathrm{conv}_k(h)$: a small learned convolution blended half and half ($\rho = 0.5$) with its input, which smooths the blocky stretched result.
4. **Subtract.** Remove what this level explained, so the next level only describes what is left. sg (stop-gradient) means the subtraction is not differentiated.

The reconstruction after level k is the sum of everything explained so far:

$$\hat{z}_k = \sum_{j \le k} q_j, \qquad \hat{z} = \hat{z}_{K-1} \approx z.$$

Decoding $\hat{z}_k$ for $k < K-1$ gives the "after level k" texts of Figure 1.

Codebook updates. Codebooks are not trained by gradients. After each step every entry moves towards the average of the vectors assigned to it:

$$N_j \leftarrow \gamma N_j + (1-\gamma)\, n_j, \qquad m_j \leftarrow \gamma m_j + (1-\gamma) \sum_{i:\, c_i = j} x_i, \qquad E[j] = m_j / \tilde{N}_j.$$

Reading it: n_j counts how many vectors picked entry j in this batch, N_j is its running average with decay $\gamma = 0.99$, m_j the running sum of those vectors, and $\tilde{N}_j$ is N_j with a tiny amount added to every count (Laplace smoothing) so nothing is divided by zero. Entries nobody uses (N_j below a threshold) restart at a random input vector.

Losses. The decoder, one transformer block, reads $\tilde{z} = z + \mathrm{sg}(\hat{z} - z)$. Numerically this *is* $\hat{z}$, but its gradient flows into z as if quantisation were the identity (the straight-through estimator), so the encoder learns. The training loss is

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{codec}} = \underbrace{\mathrm{CE}\big(\mathrm{Dec}(\tilde{z}), x\big)}_{\text{rebuild the tokens}} + \underbrace{\frac{1}{K}\sum_k \Big(\beta\,\|\mathrm{sg}(\hat{z}_k) - z\|^2 + \|\hat{z}_k - \mathrm{sg}(z)\|^2\Big)}_{\text{VQ loss}}, \quad \beta = 0.25.$$

Reading it: the first term asks the decoder to rebuild the exact tokens. The *commitment* term (β) pulls the encoder output towards what the codes can express; the *fit* term trains the refinement convolutions ϕ_k so each partial sum $\hat{z}_k$ is as close to z as possible.

Fine-level dropout. Half of the time the decoder receives $\hat{z}_k$ for a random $k < K-1$ instead of the full $\hat{z}$. It must then make sense of a coarse-only description, which is why every prefix of levels decodes to a plausible sequence: a form of nested dropout (Rippel et al. 2014).

Learned level 0. Averaging an entire Sudoku grid into one vector gives nearly the same vector for every grid, so level 0 carries no information (Section 7.2). Upstream replaces D_0 and U_0 by a strided convolution and a transposed convolution initialised to behave like pooling and repetition. Picking a code has no gradient, so the gradient reaches them through a straight-through estimator: q_0 is built from $x_0 + \mathrm{sg}(E_0[c_0] - x_0)$, whose value is the code vector and whose gradient is that of x_0.

5.2 Generator: predicting one level from the levels above

The generator is a transformer that reads one long row of vectors:

$$[\ \text{prefix}\ (P)\ |\ \text{level-0 queries}\ (l_0)\ |\ \text{input}_1\ (l_1)\ |\ \ldots\ |\ \text{input}_{K-1}\ (l_{K-1})\ ], \qquad \text{input}_k = D_k\, \hat{z}_{k-1}.$$

Reading it: the *prefix* holds the conditioning, for Sudoku the 81 cells of the puzzle (blanks as 0). Level 0 has nothing above it, so it reads learned query vectors. Every other level reads the reconstruction from all coarser levels, shrunk to its own length. Toy example: input_2 is $\hat{z}_1$ (levels 0 and 1 combined) averaged down to 4 positions. Head k turns each of the l_k positions of its block into a probability for each of the V codes of level k.

Training loss. With the true codes c_k of a training example,

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{gen}} = \frac{\sum_k l_k \cdot \text{CE}_k}{\sum_k l_k}, \qquad \text{CE}_k = -\frac{1}{l_k} \sum_{i=1}^{l_k} \log p_\theta \left(c_{k,i} \mid \text{input}_k, \text{prefix} \right).$$

Reading it: CE_k is the average surprise at the true codes of level k; weighting by l_k makes every code count equally (the paper's $\alpha = 0$ setting (Kumbong et al. 2026, App. F.2.3)). A uniform guess among 16 codes scores $\ln 16 \approx 2.77$.

Attention pattern. Positions of level k may read the prefix and the other positions of level k, nothing else (*block-diagonal* attention); coarser levels reach level k only through input_k. Two consequences follow. Training on the whole row at once computes exactly what level-by-level generation computes (tested, Section 6.2). And each level's codes are chosen without seeing each other's choices, the source of both the speed and errors like "red" → "ret". RoPE (Su et al. 2021) positions restart at zero in every level, a learned level embedding tells levels apart, and queries and keys are RMS-normalised.

Conditioning corruption. In training the generator reads true coarser codes; in generation it reads its own, sometimes wrong, codes. Upstream narrows this gap by replacing a fraction p_k of the conditioning codes of level k with random codes of the same level, keeping the true codes as targets, with p_k falling linearly across levels (Kumbong et al. 2026, Sec. 3.4):

$$p_k = p_{\text{first}} + (p_{\text{last}} - p_{\text{first}}) \frac{k}{K-2}, \qquad k = 0, \ldots, K-2.$$

This is the coarse-to-fine analogue of scheduled sampling (Bengio et al. 2015). The paper notes that corruption "based on the model's actual errors may better match inference conditions" but does not test it; experiment E9 tests it and finds no gain at our scale (Section 8).

5.3 Generation

For $k = 0, \ldots, K-1$: run the generator on input_k and the prefix, sample all l_k codes of level k at once, add their contribution q_k to the reconstruction and shrink it into input_{k+1}. Finally decode $\hat{z}_{K-1}$ to tokens. Cost: K generator passes and one decoder pass, independent of how long each level is.

Table 2: Differences between this implementation and the released NCM Sudoku setting (Kumbong et al. 2026, Tables 5–6).

Component	Upstream	This work
Tokens per board	89 (cells and separators)	81 (cells)
Levels × codes	12×16, $l_{K-1} = 89$	12×16, $l_{K-1} = 81$
Level-0 sampler	learned (one layer, as 89 is prime)	learned from E6, one layer
Codec training	10,000 updates × batch 1,024, lr 5e-4	$3{,}000 \times 128$, lr 2e-4
Generator	8×512 (25.5M), 50,000 updates × 1,024, lr 3e-4	8×256 (6.4M), $4{,}000 \times 128$, lr 6e-4
Conditioning corruption	yes, linear schedule	from E8 (0.30 → 0.05)
Models	one per difficulty	one for all difficulties

6 Implementation on Apple Silicon

> **In short.** Pure MLX and NumPy, no code copied from upstream. Two findings matter beyond this project: Apple GPUs compute fp32 matrix products at reduced precision, and block-diagonal attention is faster computed per level than through a mask.

6.1 Framework mapping

Codebooks and their running averages are frozen MLX arrays updated outside automatic differentiation; the shrink and stretch operators D_k, U_k are precomputed matrices; attention uses MLX's fused `scaled_dot_product_attention`. Weights are stored as safetensors. The correspondence to upstream is documented component by component in `docs/research/upstream-map.md`.

6.2 Exactness and Metal precision

A test asserts that level-by-level generation produces the same logits as the training forward. On the Metal GPU the two disagreed by about 5×10^{-4}. Against a float64 NumPy reference, the same fp32 computation had an error of 1.4×10^{-2} on the GPU and 2×10^{-6} on the CPU: fp32 matrix products on Metal run at reduced internal precision, about 10^{-3} relative. Exactness tests therefore run on the CPU, and a separate test checks the GPU path within 5×10^{-3}. This matters for anyone writing equivalence tests for MLX models; it does not affect sampling quality.

6.3 Segmented block-diagonal attention

With a mask, attention over the full Sudoku row forms a 395×395 score matrix per head, most of it masked out. Computing attention separately for the prefix and for each level (keys and values: prefix plus that level) gives the same result with $P^2 + \sum_k l_k(P + l_k) \approx 48,000$ scores instead of 156,000. In training (width 256, batch 128, compiled) step time fell from 1.59 s to 1.18 s and peak memory from 18.7 GB to 16.4 GB, measured back to back. A test checks equality with the masked computation.

6.4 Compilation and precision

Compiling the training step with `mx.compile` cut step time by about 1.3× (1.22 s → 0.92 s at width 256, batch 128). Casting the generator to bfloat16 gave a further 1.4–1.8× in a first test but saved no memory, because the frozen fp32 codec promotes the generator's inputs back to fp32; mixed precision is not used in the experiments reported here.

6.5 Interrupted training and reproducibility

Long runs need recoverable training state as well as model weights. Codec and generator snapshots now store optimizer moments and step, random state, shuffled-batch position, elapsed training time and model parameters; codec snapshots include VQ running averages and generator snapshots retain the best-validation model. Files are replaced atomically, with a preceding snapshot retained. A pause signal saves after the current step; a hard crash recovers from the last completed snapshot. Short CPU tests give identical saved state for uninterrupted and resumed training, including the compiled generator path. This does not establish equality across hardware or backends. Rented-pod recovery also depends on copying snapshots outside the container before it disappears.

E17 exposed the distinction: closing its terminal killed training after the last saved step, 30,000 of 32,000. That legacy checkpoint contained weights alone. Its continuation retains the learning-rate and batch positions but resets optimizer moments and random state, so it must be reported as a weights-only recovery. The recovered model solves 71.25 / 31.75 / 3.70% of easy/medium/hard boards, close to E13, after 2,000 continuation steps taking 1,247.53 s. This is consistent with puzzle construction affecting transfer, but the reset prevents a controlled causal conclusion. The operational procedure is documented in `docs/RECOVERY.md`.

7 Experiments

> **In short.** On a small invented language NCM is faster and somewhat less accurate than an equal-size AR model. On Sudoku our AR baseline matches the paper's AR result; our NCM does not match the paper's NCM.

Runs use an Apple M5 Pro (64 GB unified memory, macOS 26.5), an RTX 3080 or a rented A40, as labelled for each experiment, with MLX 0.32.3. Other GPU workloads often ran on the Mac; timings this affects are marked.

7.1 TinyWorld: an invented language

TinyWorld has 15,360 sentences of the form *name verb count adjective noun*, with number agreement ("one red cat", "two red cats"), at most 32 characters. 12,000 sentences train the models; the rest are held out. A sentence is *valid* if it parses and agrees. The codec (6 levels, $l = 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 128$ codes each, 1.3M parameters) rebuilds 100% of held-out sentences exactly. The NCM generator (5.0M parameters) is compared with a character-level AR transformer of the same width and depth (4.8M parameters) with a KV cache.

Table 3: TinyWorld, equal-size NCM and AR models (E1).

	NCM	AR
Valid, temperature 1.0	89.8%	98.6%
Valid, temperature 0.7	95.8%	99.8%
Valid and not in the training set, temperature 1.0	16.3%	23.5%
Forward passes per sequence	6 + 1 decode	32
Median latency, batch 1 / 16 / 256	4.5 / 5.8 / 37.8 ms	30.5 / 22.9 / 49.8 ms

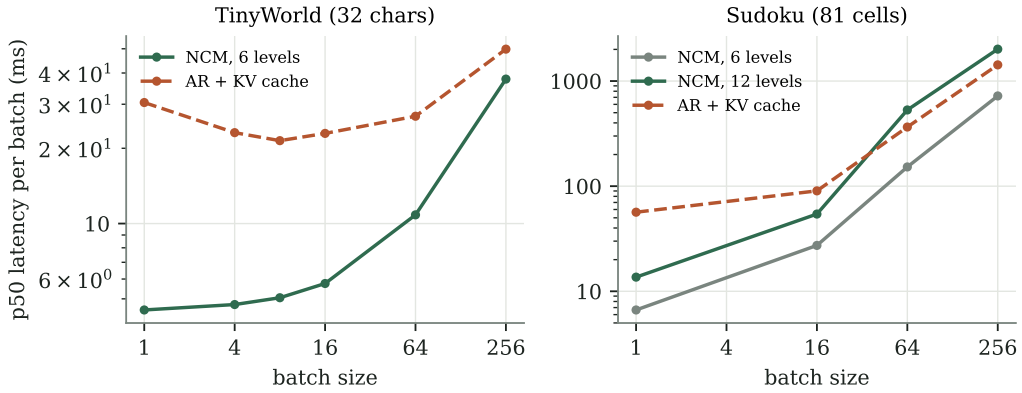


Figure 2: Median latency per batch for NCM and AR models. Left: TinyWorld. Right: Sudoku. Both axes logarithmic.

NCM is less accurate and faster. Its errors are local spelling slips; agreement, a sentence-wide rule, holds in 99.8% of well-formed samples. Forcing the true codes for the first k levels and sampling the rest (E2) shows that errors arise at every level, not only the finest. Letting level k also read coarser levels (block-causal attention, E3) raised validity at temperature 1 from 89.8% to 92.2% (n = 1,024, standard error about 0.9 points) at 1.5–1.9× the latency.

7.2 Sudoku

Each board is 81 digits; the puzzle (blanks as 0) is the prefix and the solution is the target. Training uses 200,000 synthetic puzzles from randomised backtracking with 28–45 givens. Test sets are the 2,000 easy, medium and hard boards (40, 35 and 30 givens) published with the NCM paper. A board counts as *solved* if the output is a valid grid that keeps every given. Decoding is greedy.

Table 4: Sudoku, share of boards solved. Paper rows are quoted from (Kumbong et al. 2026, Table 3).

Model	Params	Easy	Medium	Hard
NCM, this work, E4–E6	6.4M	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
NCM, this work, E8 (+ corruption)	6.4M	6.2%	0.35%	0.0%
NCM, this work, E11 (+ 4× data)	6.4M	55.2%	18.1%	1.6%
NCM, this work, E13 (+ stronger corruption)	6.4M	70.9%	31.2%	4.0%
NCM, this work, E14 (+ 16× data)	6.4M	87.4%	53.4%	11.2%
NCM, this work, E15 (all levers)	6.4M	**96.2%**	**76.6%**	**31.9%**
AR, this work	6.3M	13.8%	3.0%	0.4%
AR, this work, E11′s budget (2M sequences)	6.3M	20.5%	4.9%	0.5%
Qwen3.8 27B, 4-bit, no reasoning (50 boards each)	27B	0%	0%	0%
AR greedy, paper	25M	14.6%	5.1%	1.0%
MDLM, paper	29M	92.0%	77.1%	30.2%
NCM, paper	25M	99.5%	96.5%	86.1%

The AR row matches the paper's AR row to within two points, which checks the boards, the scoring and the conditioning path. The NCM rows do not match. Without conditioning corruption (E4–E6) our NCM solves nothing; with it (E8) it solves 6.2% of easy boards and fills 74.7% of blank cells correctly, more than the AR model's 71.0%, while still solving fewer boards. With four times more training data (E11) it solves 55.2% of easy boards and beats the AR model at every difficulty; given the same 2M training sequences, the AR model solves 20.5%, 4.9% and 0.5%, so the advantage is not a budget artefact. Section 8 isolates the steps.

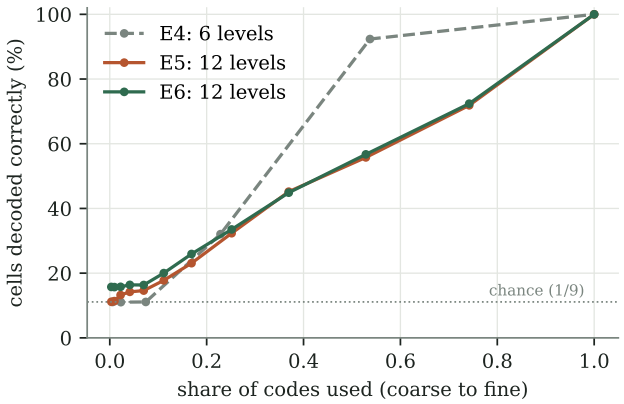


Figure 3: Cell accuracy when decoding from the first k levels of the codec, against the share of codes used. E4 stores almost all information in one level; E5 and E6 refine gradually.

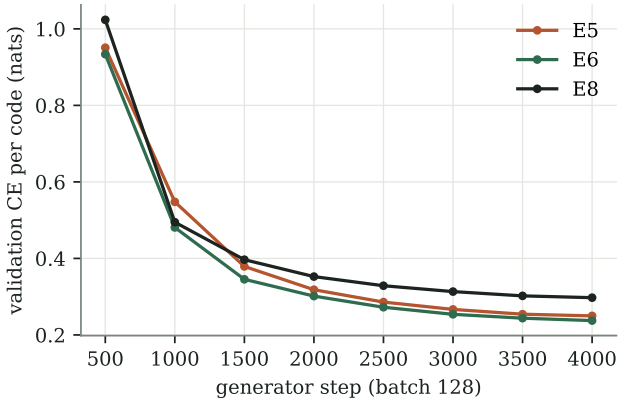


Figure 4: Validation cross-entropy per code during generator training.

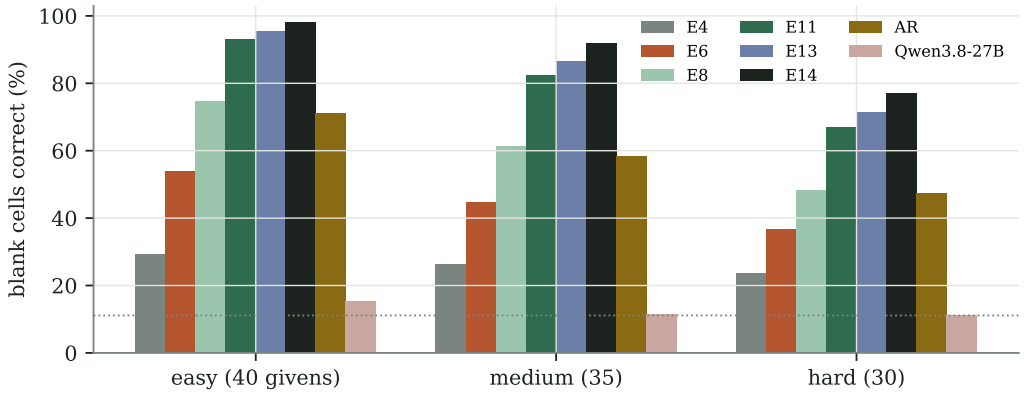


Figure 5: Blank cells filled with the reference digit, per test set. Chance is about 11%.

Why per-cell gains do not become solved boards. A board is about 300 codes. Teacher-forced accuracy per level in E6 ranges from 25% (level 0, which the puzzle barely determines) to 99.6% (the last level); generating greedily, an error at an early level changes the inputs of every later level. E8′s corruption training attacks exactly this compounding. Even 98% accuracy per cell, with independent errors, would solve only $0.98^{41} \approx 44\%$ of easy boards, which have 41 blanks. The paper's generator was trained on about 51 million sequences; E6 saw 0.5 million.

7.3 A large chat model as reference

Qwen3.8 27B (4-bit, served locally) answered each board in one request at temperature 0 with reasoning disabled. It solved none of 150 boards; its blank-cell accuracy was 11–15%, near chance, and about half its replies were not a 9×9 grid. With reasoning enabled and up to 6,000 tokens per board it did not finish ten boards in 95 minutes on the shared GPU. This is a reference point, not a matched comparison: the model is about 4,000 times larger and was not trained on the task.

8 The journey: experiment by experiment

> **In short.** Each experiment changed one thing. Experiment numbers (E0, E1, …) follow the order in which they were run; the full record with every number is in `docs/EXPERIMENTS.md`.

Table 5: Experiments in order. Sudoku results are for the easy test boards.

Run	Question	Change from the previous run	Result	What we learned
E0	Does the pipeline work end to end?	First version, 4,000 TinyWorld sentences	94.6% valid; overfits	The codec rebuilds 99.4% of sentences; models need more data
E1	NCM vs AR, fairly	12,000 sentences, best-validation checkpoints	NCM 89.8% vs AR 98.6% valid; 4–5× faster	Speed holds on a laptop; the accuracy gap is real
E2	Which level causes errors?	Force true codes for levels 0..k	Errors at every level	Not only the finest level is at fault
E3	Does reading coarser levels help?	Block-causal attention	92.2% valid, 1.5–1.9× slower	Small gain; kept as an option
E4	Does NCM solve Sudoku?	Puzzle as prefix, 6 levels	0% solved; AR 13.8%	One level holds all information: no real coarse-to-fine
E5	Does upstream's level schedule fix it?	12 levels × 16 codes, lookup encoder	0%; blank cells 52% (was 29%)	Gradual refinement, but level 0 is dead
E6	Does a learned level 0 fix it?	Learned level-0 sampler, GroupNorm, lower codec lr	0%; blank cells 54%	Level 0 now used; small gains; diverges at lr 1e-3
E7	Upstream's generator width	8×512	stopped early	Recipe search showed corruption was missing; GPU time moved to E8
E8	Does conditioning corruption help?	Uniform corruption 0.30 → 0.05	6.2% solved; blank cells 74.7%	The largest single gain: first solved boards; beats AR on blank cells; validation loss gets worse while generation gets better

Run	Question	Change from the previous run	Result	What we learned
E9	Does corruption from the model's own samples help more?	Replacements drawn from the generator	3.0% solved; blank cells 74.7%	No: same blank cells, fewer solved boards, 1.56× training time
E10	Upstream's width	8 × 512, lr 3e-4, 1.5M sequences, on the Mac	55.9% / 18.4% / 2.0%	Width alone does not help at this budget: matches the 256-wide E11
E11	More data	E8 on 2M sequences (4×), RTX 3080	55.2% easy, 18.1% medium, 1.6% hard solved	Data was the largest remaining lever; NCM now beats the same-size AR model
E12	Upstream's width on a rented GPU	8 × 512, stronger corruption, 3.25M sequences, NVIDIA A40	74.6% / 35.2% / 6.0%	Width adds little; data still dominates
E13	Stronger corruption	0.50 → 0.10 at E11′s budget	70.9% / 31.2% / 4.0%	Corruption strength matters: +16 points on easy
E14	Even more data	E11 on 8.2M sequences (16× E8)	87.4% / 53.4% / 11.2%	Data keeps paying; still not saturated
E16	Fresh unique puzzles vs repetition	E13 on 2M greedy-unique puzzles seen once	57.6% / 21.8% / 2.2%	Worse than E13: how puzzles are built matters more than uniqueness
E17	Unique puzzles built like the test boards	E13 on random-removal puzzles that happen to be unique; weights-only recovery	71.25% / 31.75% / 3.70%	Close to E13; optimizer reset limits interpretation
E15	Both levers + unique-solution puzzles	E14 budget, corruption 0.50 → 0.10, +4M unique puzzles	96.2% / 76.6% / 31.9%	Within 3.3 points of the paper on easy, with a quarter of the model and a sixth of the data
E18	Both levers, base data only	E14 budget, corruption 0.50 → 0.10	*in progress*	
E19	Paper-scale budget on a rented GPU	E15 recipe, 8M unique puzzles, ≈45M sequences, NVIDIA A40	*planned*	

What the journey shows. The first Sudoku configuration failed for a reason no reconstruction test would reveal: its codec rebuilds boards perfectly yet places nearly all information in one level (Figure 3, E4), so the generator faces one large guess instead of a series of small ones. The fixes taken from upstream each helped a little and none was enough on its own. Reading the paper's appendix in full showed the two largest gaps: conditioning corruption and a training budget about a hundred times larger. Corruption alone (E8) produced the first solved boards and lifted blank-cell accuracy by 20 points on every test set. Its validation loss was *worse* than without corruption, a reminder that teacher-forced loss does not measure what generation needs.

9 Discussion

What carries over to a laptop. The structural speed argument holds on Apple Silicon: with few short levels, NCM's latency at batch 1–16 is a fraction of an equal-size AR model's, because each pass reads the weights once for many positions. The advantage shrinks with batch size and with the total number of codes; the 12-level Sudoku model, with 314 codes plus an 81-token prefix, is slower than AR from batch 64 on.

What does not carry over without the full recipe. The codec-side components we added (E5, E6) improved every secondary metric a little and none moved solved boards; conditioning corruption (E8) did. The paper's result rests on a combination of recipe and scale that small, short runs do not reach. A codec whose coarse levels look informative is necessary but far from sufficient.

Negative results worth reporting. Two first choices made the method fail in ways reconstruction metrics hide: a level schedule that concentrates information in one level, and an area-pooled first level that encodes nothing. Both pass a codec test with 100% reconstruction.

10 Limitations

Most generator runs use at most 6.4M parameters; width-512 ablations use 25M. Training budgets range from minutes to hours. The only language-like task is synthetic; the paper's text benchmarks (LM1B, OpenWebText, XSum, WMT14) were not run. Latency measurements share the GPU with other workloads unless stated. The upstream training code is not public, so recipe details not stated in the paper are guesses.

11 Related work

Parallel and coarse-to-fine decoding for text includes discrete diffusion (Sahoo et al. 2024) and the methods compared in (Kumbong et al. 2026). Residual quantisation is standard in audio codecs (Zeghidour et al. 2021) and image generation (Lee et al. 2022; Tian et al. 2024). Scheduled sampling (Bengio et al. 2015) addresses the train–test mismatch that conditioning corruption targets. We found one public project adding PyTorch training loops to the upstream modules (Bakhaow/ncm-forge) and no other MLX implementation.

12 Conclusion

NCM can be implemented natively in MLX with a provably consistent training and generation path, and on a laptop GPU it delivers the low small-batch latency its design promises. Reproducing its accuracy is a different matter: on Sudoku, matching the published AR baseline was easy and matching NCM was not, and the gap closes slowly as upstream's recipe is added piece by piece. Conditioning corruption, which addresses the gap between training on true codes and generating from the model's own, was the single most effective change. A variant based on the model's own samples, suggested in the paper, did not help (E9). Larger training budgets and real-text evaluation remain to be tested.

Code and reproducibility

Code, configurations and this paper: github.com/janmus1c/ncm-mlx (private until release). Every configuration is in `configs/`; every run is logged in `docs/EXPERIMENTS.md`.

```
git clone https://github.com/janmus1c/ncm-mlx && cd ncm-mlx
mise run setup                                  # Python 3.12, MLX, tests
scripts/run_experiment.sh configs/sudoku-e6.json   # train, evaluate, benchmark
.venv/bin/python paper/make_figures.py          # rebuild data and figures
paper/build.sh                                  # rebuild this paper
```

References

Bengio, Samy, Oriol Vinyals, Navdeep Jaitly, and Noam Shazeer. 2015. 'Scheduled Sampling for Sequence Prediction with Recurrent Neural Networks'. *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems*.

Hannun, Awni, Jagrit Digani, Angelos Katharopoulos, and Ronan Collobert. 2023. *MLX: Efficient and Flexible Machine Learning on Apple Silicon*. Https://github.com/ml-explore/mlx.

Kumbong, Hermann, Ishan S. Khare, Iddah Mlauzi, et al. 2026. 'Next-Concept Modeling: Fast, Parallel Coarse-to-Fine Text Generation'. *arXiv Preprint arXiv:2610.14162*.

Lee, Doyup, Chiheon Kim, Saehoon Kim, Minsu Cho, and Wook-Shin Han. 2022. 'Autoregressive Image Generation Using Residual Quantization'. *Proceedings of the IEEE/CVF Conference on Computer Vision and Pattern Recognition*.

Oord, Aaron van den, Oriol Vinyals, and Koray Kavukcuoglu. 2017. 'Neural Discrete Representation Learning'. *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems*.

Rippel, Oren, Michael Gelbart, and Ryan Adams. 2014. 'Learning Ordered Representations with Nested Dropout'. *International Conference on Machine Learning*.

Sahoo, Subham Sekhar, Marianne Arriola, Yair Schiff, et al. 2024. 'Simple and Effective Masked Diffusion Language Models'. *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems*.

Su, Jianlin, Yu Lu, Shengfeng Pan, Ahmed Murtadha, Bo Wen, and Yunfeng Liu. 2021. 'RoFormer: Enhanced Transformer with Rotary Position Embedding'. *arXiv Preprint arXiv:2104.09864*.

Tian, Keyu, Yi Jiang, Zehuan Yuan, Bingyue Peng, and Liwei Wang. 2024. 'Visual Autoregressive Modeling: Scalable Image Generation via Next-Scale Prediction'. *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems*.

Zeghidour, Neil, Alejandro Luebs, Ahmed Omran, Jan Skoglund, and Marco Tagliasacchi. 2021. 'SoundStream: An End-to-End Neural Audio Codec'. *IEEE/ACM Transactions on Audio, Speech, and Language Processing*.

Appendix A: Hyperparameters

Table 6: Main settings per experiment. All runs: AdamW, weight decay 0.01, cosine schedule with warmup, batch 128, commitment $\beta = 0.25$, fine-level dropout 0.5.

Run	Levels	Codes	Codec	Codec steps (lr)	Generator	Gen. steps (lr)	Other
E1	1,2,4,8,16,32	128	128 wide, 2+2 blocks	3,000 (1e-3)	6×256	4,000 (6e-4)	EMA 0.95
E4	1,3,9,27,54,81	32	2 encoder blocks	3,000 (1e-3)	8×256	5,000 (6e-4)	prefix 81
E5	1,2,4,6,9,13,18,26,37,50,67,81	16	lookup encoder, 1 decoder block, 256 wide	3,000 (1e-3)	8×256	4,000 (6e-4)	EMA 0.99
E6	as E5	16	E5 + learned level 0, GroupNorm(8), dropout 0.3	3,000 (2e-4)	8×256	4,000 (6e-4)	
E8	as E5	16	E6 codec	—	8×256	4,000 (6e-4)	corruption $0.30 \rightarrow 0.05$, compiled
E9	as E5	16	E6 codec	—	8×256	4,000 (6e-4)	as E8, model-sampled

Appendix B: Environment

Apple M5 Pro, 64 GB unified memory, macOS 26.5; MLX 0.32.3, NumPy, Python 3.12.14 managed with mise and uv. Figures: matplotlib. Paper: Pandoc and Typst.

Appendix C: Version history

Version	Date	Changes
0.1	2026-10-23	First draft: method, implementation, TinyWorld and Sudoku results E0–E6.
0.2	2026-10-23	Plain-language introduction, glossary, formulas explained with a running example, experiment journey (E0–E9), hyperparameter appendix, NeurIPS-style layout, HTML, EPUB, LaTeX, JATS and DOCX editions.
0.3	2026-10-23	E8 results: conditioning corruption gives the first solved boards.
0.4	2026-10-23	E11: four times the training data gives 55% of easy boards; first run on NVIDIA.
0.5	2026-10-24	E13 (stronger corruption) and E14 (16× data): 87% of easy boards.
0.6	2026-10-24	E15 combines data, stronger corruption and unique puzzles: 96% of easy boards. Layout checks on every build.
0.7	2026-10-24	Full-state pause/resume and recovery checks; E17′s weights-only continuation solves 71.25% of easy boards, with the optimizer-reset qualification.